

HACKING OPERA'S INI FILES

Opera and Firefox are nibbling away at IE's share of the browser market, as you very well know... Firefox has hundreds of downloadable add-ons if you need more features, whereas Opera comes preinstalled with many of them. Some of the features can be tweaked to become more useful, so we'll look at ways to customise the just-released Opera 9.3 using just its INI files.

Setting Up Fast Forward To Work Better

Opera has a feature called Fast Forward, which allows you to browse to the next page in sequence (for example, a sequence of pages in a Google search) without having to click the link. It works by using certain keywords or code in pages. Although it is a useful feature, it doesn't always seem to work as well as you want it to. You can add more or make changes to existing keywords to make this feature a little more useful.

The .ini file that contains the keywords is fastforward.ini, and is located in Opera's installed folder—usually C:\Program Files\Opera. (We'll assume you've installed Opera on your C drive.) Open it in Notepad. Add suitable keywords to the list, for example, To Page.

Opera Customisation From A Single Page

Like in almost all browsers, the "about:" scheme is used to display features and other information about the browser in Opera. The about:config link, specifically, allows you to change a lot more settings than you normally get access to through the Preferences window. Click on the address bar and enter about:config and press Enter. Here you can expand each of the features and make changes to the settings. Most of



Most of Opera's features can be customized using about:config

the tips that we'll be talking of won't be there on this list.

Fight Ads Using Opera's Filter

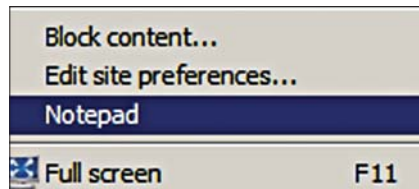
Ads are everywhere on almost any site you visit. Firefox may have Adblock Plus, but Opera has its own ad blocking system in place. The file urlfilter.ini in C:\Documents and Settings\Your_Username\Application Data\Opera\Opera\profile contains a list of sites to be blocked. Add site addresses and wildcards such as "*" (the Star) to block sites. There are several such lists available on the Internet ready for download. One such good list can be found at www.fanboy.co.nz/adblock/. Just download the Opera list and copy the file to the given location or its contents to the file that already exists.

Modifying Tab Width Range

Tabbed browsing is a boon, but the use of too many tabs in Opera causes the names to be cropped off. This makes reading the tab headings close to impossible. You can set a limit to how small and how wide a tab can be allowed to be. Extract the skin.ini from the skin.zip from c:\Program Files\Opera\skin. Open skin.ini in Notepad and modify these lines: Pagebar max button width = ____ Pagebar min button width = ____ to suitable values. If the lines aren't present, create them and then save the file. Add the edited file back to the skin's ZIP file. Restart Opera and select the skin from Tools > Appearance.

Adding Program Shortcuts To Opera's Menu

Opera's menu can be used not just for browsing-related functions, it also



Programs can be launched directly through the browser

allows you to start up Windows applications! First create a copy of your standard_menu.ini. Select Tools > Preferences. Click on Toolbars in the left pane. Click the lone Menu Setup, then click Duplicate. Now, you need to open the newly created duplicate standard_menu.ini in Notepad located at C:\Documents and Settings\Your_Username\Application

Data\Opera\Opera\profile\menu. To create an entry, scroll down till you reach the [Document Popup Menu] section. Create entries using the following format. Here, we've created an entry for starting Notepad. Item, "Start Notepad" = "Execute Program, "Notepad.exe" " Save the file and restart Opera.

Adding Shortcuts To Execute Programs

Keyboard shortcuts can be used in Opera to quickly start programs to go to a particular site. The trick is to add shortcuts to the shortcut.ini file located at C:\Documents and Settings\Your_Username\Application Data\Opera\Opera\profile\keyboard. Open it in Notepad. Creating shortcuts is done in manner similar to this:

```
G,G="Execute program,
"c:\WINDOWS\Notepad.exe"
```

Here, typing [G] [G] will start Notepad. In a similar manner, the path of the program can be replaced with a site URL, for example, ="Execute program, "www.thinkdigit.com". Opera will load the site when you use the shortcuts.

Opening A Page In A Different Browser

If you're visiting a page and want it to be opened in a different browser, which is sometimes needed because Opera

Open	
Open in new tab	Shift+Enter
Open in background tab	Ctrl+Shift+Enter
Open in new window	
Open in background window	
Bookmark link...	
Copy link address	Ctrl+Alt+C
Save target as...	Ctrl+Shift+S
Save to download folder	
Open in Firefox	

Sites can be viewed on different browsers if needed

can't render it properly, you can create a new entry in the menu when you right-click. Browse to C:\Documents and Settings\Your_Username\Application Data\Opera\Opera\profile\menu. Open the standard_menu.ini file in Notepad. Create an entry in the [Link Popup Menu] in the following format:

```
Item, "Open link in Firefox" =
Execute program, "firefox", "%l"
```

You can use a similar format for Internet Explorer. Save the file and restart Opera. ■